Friedrichstraße S-Bahn station. The excursion lines of the BVG buses were very busy.4

An earthier editorial was plastered on the front page of Honecker's former paper Junge Welt, which barked that the GDR would not watch passively as the 'mad Bonn warmongers' prepared for armed aggression. 'They took our patience for weakness. It is we who are on the offensive: West Berlin will no longer remain "the thorn in the flesh of the GDR".'5

On the other side of the Wall, ARD television news gave it twenty-two minutes – an eternity on a twenty-five-minute evening news programme – and followed up with a second instalment. Meanwhile, special editions of newspapers were rushed out. BZ, the local paper for West Berlin, screamed that the date of 13 August 1961 would never be forgotten, because on that day:

a bunch of people led by Soviet citizen Ulbricht, committed a crime against humanity. These men who call themselves the leaders of a worker's state, in reality, are nothing but a group of concentration camp supervisors.

They have converted Central Germany into a concentration camp. And yesterday they blocked the ultimate gate which so far has led to freedom. These blockade measures are solely for the protection of Ulbricht and his accomplices. The ultimate gap in the prison zone was closed so that no cry of excitement of an enslaved nation might penetrate the outside. With the blessing of Khrushchev, Pankow has torn to pieces the four-power agreements binding our city. This action must be answered by the three Western powers.

The barrier was 'barbaric', ran one report from in The Times of London. 'Herr Ulbricht's wall in Berlin must be unique in history,' Sir William Hayter, the former British ambassador to Moscow opined. 'Countries had surrounded themselves with defensive walls before, but the object has